

Mapping the ROAD to democracy: a global dataset of overturning attempts and organizations in civil resistance transitions

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Abstract

Who attempts to overturn nonviolent revolutions? And when do they succeed? There is a strong correlation between transitions initiated through primarily nonviolent civil resistance and democratization. However, in several prominent cases, civil resistance transitions have been overturned, resulting in new authoritarian regimes. Little research has examined when and how overturning occurs, and which organizations perpetrate it, in part because no data exists that comprehensively examines overturning in civil resistance transitions. In this article we present the Resistance Overturning Attempts Dataset (ROAD), a dataset of overturning attempts and the organizations participating in and resisting them in every civil resistance transition from the beginning of the Third Wave of democratization to the present. We describe the variables and data collection process, and present descriptive statistics to illustrate the data's utility. These descriptives reveal several important areas for future research, perhaps most surprisingly that the most effective tactic for safeguarding civil resistance transitions appears to be armed violence.

Keywords democratization, civil resistance, datasets, organizations, conflict

Introduction

In 2011, the Arab Spring initiated a democratic transition in Egypt. Yet after two tumultuous years the Egyptian military overturned Egypt's brief democratic experiment in a brutal military coup. In 1986, the "People Power" movement in the Philippines overthrew dictator Ferdinand Marcos. The subsequent transition was turbulent, with several coup attempts. Yet these coup attempts universally failed and the Philippines transitioned to democracy. In contrast, Mali's 1990s transition after mass protests and a national dialogue saw no attempts to overturn the country's nascent democracy.

These three transitions shared much: initiation through non-violent civil resistance, strong militaries with incentives to seize power, and histories of political instability and authoritarian rule. Yet, their trajectories diverged both in terms of democratic outcomes and number of overturning attempts.

State militaries are only one of many organizations that have attempted or succeeded in overturning civil resistance transitions. In Albania in the 1990s, the Democratic Party of Albania led a successful pro-democracy civil resistance campaign. Yet once in power the Democratic Party embarked on a campaign to suppress dissent, the result of which was the creation of a *de facto* single-party dictatorship.

What explains this variation? Why are some civil resistance transitions overturned, others challenged but survive, and some unthreatened by overturning? Which organizations drive these outcomes? In this paper we introduce a new dataset—the Resistance Overturning Attempts Dataset (ROAD)—that documents both successful and failed overturning attempts across all civil resistance transitions from 1970 to 2018, enabling deeper analysis of who challenges transitions, how, and under what conditions.

Understanding this phenomenon is critical because, as we show below, overturning attempts are common (though not ubiquitous) in civil resistance transitions. Out of the 68 political transitions in our data, 49 faced at least one attempt to overturn the transition, and many faced several attempts. In the 2010s, all civil resistance transitions faced at least one overturning attempt. The consequences of these overturning attempts are often dire. In Egypt, the 2013 coup not only led to a new authoritarian regime, but to one of the deadliest massacres of protesters in modern times.

ROAD provides the first mapping of this phenomenon. For each overturning attempt we include a detailed qualitative summary of the attempt, the mechanism of attempted overturning and whether the attempt succeeded. Building on the insights of the "organizational turn" in conflict studies (Braithwaite et al., 2026), we also include the identity of the key organizations involved in both leading and resisting the attempt (linked, where possible, to

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leading organization-level datasets). Further, we provide information on the linkages between the most important groups involved in overturning and old regimes, as well as the tactics used to resist overturning attempts.

There are several intriguing patterns in ROAD to spur future research. First, we show that while attempted overturning is common, it is typically unsuccessful. Security forces are the most common organization attempting to overturn transitions, but remarkably ineffective in doing so. Yet if they are ineffective at overturning, security forces are remarkably effective at *resisting* overturning. Over 70% of overturning attempts originate from organizations linked to pre-transition regimes, reinforcing the threat of counter-revolutionary elites (Clarke, 2023). Yet nearly 20% of attempts were driven by former members of the civil resistance campaign.

We first place our data collection in the literature on civil resistance and democratization, highlighting three questions that the data can address, and limitations in existing datasets. We then describe the data collection process, and present descriptive statistics and applications of the data's utility. By systematically identifying the actors, mechanisms, and contexts involved in both successful and failed overturning attempts, we aim to present the ROAD dataset as a platform to further the exploration of civil resistance transitions and their outcomes.

Civil resistance in the democratization literature

Why countries democratize is one of comparative politics' most central questions. One tradition emphasizes elite pacts and negotiations (O'Donnell & Schmitter 1986), while others highlight structural factors such as economic development (Przeworski, 2000) and the international context (Levitsky & Way, 2010). One consistent finding throughout this literature is a strong correlation between transitions initiated through primarily nonviolent civil resistance ("civil resistance transitions" from here forward) and democracy (Bethke & Pinckney, 2021; Bogati et al., 2025; Celestino & Gleditsch, 2013; Chenoweth & Stephan, 2011).

Yet there are many unanswered questions on the *mechanisms* explaining this correlation. Most studies assert multiple non-exclusive plausible mechanisms (see e.g., Celestino & Gleditsch, 2013, p. 391). This approach is useful when the research objective is to provide plausible theoretical grounding for a macro-level correlation between civil resistance and democracy. However, it leaves much to be desired in understanding civil resistance's impact.¹

Few scholars have examined when civil resistance transitions end in democracy and when they do not. Almost all work on the subject compares civil resistance transitions with other transitions. An exception is Pinckney (2020), yet this work relies on aggregated transition-level indicators and does not examine the fine-grained political dynamics leading from civil resistance to democratization.

¹ To the extent that prior studies focused on civil resistance transitions have unpacked and tested mechanisms, they do so in single case studies (See, e.g., Bhattarai et al., 2026), or a small number of case comparisons (See e.g., Kadivar et al., 2020), providing limited ground for broader inference.

Why collect data on overturning attempts?

Yet as highlighted by our introductory examples, civil resistance transitions vary significantly not just in their outcomes, but also in their processes. Some have reverted to authoritarianism, some have democratized despite many attempts to overturn democracy, and some have never faced any attempts to overturn democracy.

Mapping overturning patterns enables several areas of new research into this variation. First, it can disaggregate the stages of democratization. Scholars of both conflict and democratization increasingly incorporate multistage processes into their analysis (e.g., Houle & Kayser, 2019; Marino et al., 2020). For instance, D. E. Cunningham et al., (2017) highlight how the onset of violent or nonviolent resistance is best understood as a two-stage process: claims-making and then, conditional on claims, the choice of violence or nonviolence. Similarly, ROAD's data on both successful and failed overturning attempts enables analysis of two distinct stages: the conditions that lead to overturning attempts and those that shape their outcomes. Studies focusing solely on democratization risk missing the critical first stage and thus may misidentify key causal factors.

Second, examining overturning attempts helps distinguish among mechanisms linking civil resistance to democratization. One view emphasizes norm change: successful civil resistance fosters an inclusive, peaceful political culture (Garcia-Ponce & Wantchekon, 2024; Lambach et al., 2020). Another emphasizes power diffusion: civil resistance empowers civil society to check future authoritarian backsliding (Ekiert & Kubik, 2001; Pinckney, 2020). Data on overturning attempts can distinguish between these mechanisms since transitions characterized by frequent attempts to overturn democracy cannot, in our view, plausibly be characterized as having a democratic and inclusive political culture. The descriptive patterns of overturning attempts can then inform research on when each of these mechanisms operates.

Third, the dataset allows exploration of how organizational preferences for or against democracy evolve during transitions. Canonical democratization models often assume consistent preferences. For instance, O'Donnell and Schmitter (1986) emphasize elite pacts between stable groups of "soft-liners" and "moderates," while political economy accounts stress static interests of elites who may support or resist democracy depending on redistribution threats (Acemoglu & Robinson, 2005; Ansell & Samuels, 2010; Boix, 2003).

Yet transitions often reshape political preferences. As studies of authoritarian successor parties show, formerly autocratic actors can support democracy (Loxton & Mainwaring, 2018).² Organizations once involved in civil resistance may cease to exist in the post-campaign transition (Vüllers & Bakken 2026), or undermine democracy once in power (Beissinger, 2013; Pinckney, 2023). Mapping not just the outcomes of overturning but also the actors involved can inform theories of shifting democratic preferences, especially among former activists—an underexplored group.

Comparison to existing datasets

Existing datasets on civil resistance, democracy, and political transitions are insufficient to examine overturning in civil resistance

² But see Miller (2021).

transitions because of limitations along three dimensions: *time period*, *level of detail*, and *conceptual scope*.

Numerous datasets examine civil resistance campaigns, revolutions, or individual protests (e.g., [Beissinger, 2022](#); [Braithwaite et al., 2022](#); [K. G. Cunningham et al., 2020](#); [Lakey, 2011](#)). Yet these datasets focus on the time period of the campaign or protest event, with little information on post-campaign outcomes. For example, the Nonviolent and Violent Campaigns and Outcomes (NAVCO) data project is the leading global dataset on civil resistance ([Chenoweth et al., 2018](#); [Chenoweth & Shay, 2022](#)). However, its only variables on the outcomes and longer-term impact of civil resistance relate to short-term campaign success.

Many other datasets focus on political transitions, regime breakdown, or democratization (e.g., [Boix et al., 2013](#); [Coppedge et al., 2024](#); [Geddes et al., 2014](#)). Yet these often lack detail on transitional politics, particularly failed overturning attempts. For example, the Historical Regimes Dataset (HRD), which is integrated with larger Varieties of Democracy project, provides information on regime breakdown and transition processes ([Djuve et al., 2019](#)). However, neither V-Dem nor HRD contain detailed information on overturning attempts.

Finally, there are numerous datasets that examine a particular form of overturning, but whose limited scope means they provide an incomplete picture of overturning across civil resistance transitions (e.g., [Clarke, 2023](#)). For instance, there are many richly-detailed datasets on military coups (e.g., [Chin et al., 2021](#)). However, military coups are not the only way overturning happens. Thus, data on military coups provides an incomplete picture of who attempts to overturn civil resistance transitions and when their attempts succeed or fail.

Data collection and variables of interest

Given these limitations, we have collected an original dataset on attempts to overturn democracy during civil resistance transitions from 1970 through, 2018. We provide cross-sectional data at two levels of analysis: the transition and, nested within transitions, the overturning attempt. The full dataset contains information on 68 transitions across 61 countries spanning Africa, Asia, Europe, Latin America, and the Middle East.

Our population of civil resistance transitions comes from data originally collected by [Pinckney \(2020\)](#). Pinckney defines a transition as “periods of time when one regime has broken down and a new regime is not yet in place” and civil resistance transitions as “that subset of political transitions in which civil resistance plays a crucial role in breaking down the prior regime” ([Pinckney, 2020](#), p. 16).

[Lamb and Peteru \(2021\)](#) subsequently identified specific start and end dates for each of Pinckney’s civil resistance transitions. Start dates are the moment of regime breakdown, typically when a leader or leaders leave or are forced from office. End dates are more difficult to identify, since the indicators of a new regime vary based on the regime’s character. Lamb and Peteru thus look for a variety of specific events that established a new regime: founding executive elections in the case of democratization, “abrupt” ending events such as successful coups in the case of re-autocratization, or the last day of the year the country’s

level of democracy ceases to significantly fluctuate if no distinct transition-ending event could be identified.

Our key concept of focus is *overturning attempts*. We define an overturning attempt as any sustained series of political actions aimed to move a transition away from democratization or to undermine existing democratic progress. Our touchstone for defining democracy was [Dahl \(1973\)](#), and we coded actions based on their effects on core democratic institutions rather than their stated rhetoric. An overturning attempt had to constitute a credible, organized, national-level threat to the political system. While most cases involved sustained campaigns, we also included consequential actions broadly judged as posing a real threat to democratic institutions under this effects-based criterion: when the documented effects on democratic institutions were substantial, national in scope, and ideally recognized by country experts as constituting an attempt, we coded these edge cases accordingly.³ We searched for overturning attempts during the transition period and the five years after.

We distinguish one overturning attempt from another based on *actor*, *strategy*, and *time*. For instance, a campaign by one political party to overturn a free and fair election using a combination of electoral violence, political intimidation, and parliamentary strategies would be a single overturning attempt. If a second political party pursued the same strategy but was not coordinating with the first, this would be a separate overturning attempt.

The data collection process

For each transition, the coder began by conducting an expansive review of the scholarly literature on the transition. They complemented this scholarly review with reports from well-respected think tanks and international organizations, and media sources from Nexis Uni and Factiva when necessary. We focused first on scholarly sources in recognition of well-known “access” and “editorial” biases in media sources ([Parkinson, 2024](#)).

For every transition and overturning attempt, the coder then synthesized this research in a summary. Coders were then tasked to code specific variables related to both the transitions and specific overturning attempts. Coders provided their sources and the logic of all of their coding decisions in HTML codesheets (provided with the dataset). Each datapoint underwent a minimum of two rounds of validation in terms of coding, source and selection, and event interpretation, with the authors supervising the correct interpretation of each variable.

Variables in the data

[Table 1](#) summarizes the variables in the data. The project codebook in the online-only appendix contains detailed descriptions and coding rules for all variables. For each transition we catalog whether or not there were overturning attempts, the number of attempts, whether any succeeded, and if so their mechanism of success. We also coded the primary organizations involved in overturning attempts, and the primary organizations that resisted each attempt. We collected the names of organizations as well as putting them into ten categories based on a categorization from the Anatomy of Resistance Campaigns (ARC) dataset ([Braithwaite](#)

³ See the *Coding Challenges* section in the Appendix.

Table 1 Variable categories and descriptions.

Variable	Category	Options
Transition Summary	Full summary text	Summary based on sources
Transition Overturned?	Categorical	4 mutually-exclusive options: No; No, but there were attempts; No, but democracy slowly eroded; Yes
Overturning Attempts	Integer	0 + attempts
How was the transition overturned?	Categorical	6 mutually-exclusive options: Not overturned; Military Coup; External violent overthrow; Gradual seizure of power; Legal changes; Other
Overturning Organizations	Vector of names	1 per organization
Overturner Categories	Vector of categorical variables	10 mutually-exclusive options each: Gov. Agency; Military; Party; Rebel Group; Labor; Religious; Professional Org.; Student; Other NGO/CSO; International
Overturners and the Old Regime	Categorical	4 mutually-exclusive options: old regime; civil resistance campaign; no known relationship; new organization;
Resisting Organizations	Vector of names	1 per organization
Resister Categories	Vector of categorical variables	10 mutually-exclusive options each: Gov. Agency; Military; Party; Rebel Group; Labor; Religious; Professional Org.; Student; Other NGO/CSO; International
Resister Tactics	Vector of categorical variables	7 mutually-exclusive options: Public statements; Public protests; Non-Cooperation; Nonviolent Intervention; Unarmed Violence; Armed Violence; Legal or parliamentary strategies

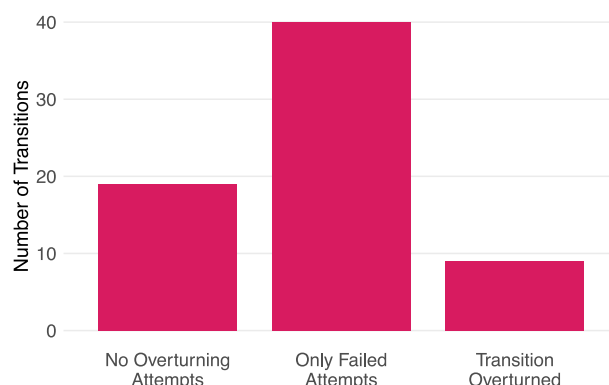
et al., 2022). We also coded whether the main overturning organizations (if present) were connected to the old regime or the civil resistance campaign that initiated the transition. Where possible, we paired organizations in our data with ID variables from the V-Party dataset (Lindberg et al., 2022) and the ARC dataset to facilitate analysis across datasets.⁴ Our last transition-level category describes the tactics were used by resisting organizations, drawing on categories from Sharp (1973) and Kadivar and Ketchley (2018).

We then coded a disaggregated version of these variables at the level of each overturning attempt. A synthesizing summary was still required to provide compact information about the major events and most important players involved in the overturning attempt. Then, we coded the start and end-dates of each overturning attempt. Finally, we captured whether each attempt could be considered fully successful, partially successful, or whether it fully failed or mostly failed.⁵ All remaining coding items fully match the transition-level segment of the dataset.

Descriptive patterns in the data

We now turn to descriptive patterns to illustrate the richness of the data.

Overturning attempts are common in civil resistance transitions, but successful overturning attempts are rare. As shown in Figure 1, out of the 68 civil resistance transitions in the data,

**Figure 1** Transitions by overturning attempts.

19 transitions had no overturning attempts and 49 had at least one overturning attempt. The large majority of those overturning attempts failed. Only 9 transitions were overturned.⁶

Who is behind these frequent overturning attempts? Figure 2 breaks down overturning organizations by their links with pre-transition politics. A large majority of overturning attempts were by organizations associated with the pre-transition regime. However, roughly 18% of overturning attempts come from former civil resistance campaign members.

Military and security forces are the most common organization type attempting overturning, yet are remarkably unsuccessful when they do so (only fully succeeding 16% of the time). Figure 3 illustrates this pattern. This figure displays the success rates of

⁴ The range of organizations in our data is different than either V-Party or ARC, thus we were only able to code these IDs for a subset of organizations. Out of a total of 526 organizations identified in our data, we were able to match 88 with V-Party IDs, and 51 with ARC IDs.

⁵ These categorizations are defined by both the stated or clearly implied objectives of the groups, and whether, according to the sources, they were able to reach their goals.

⁶ We provide additional illustrative details on a few of these cases in the appendix.

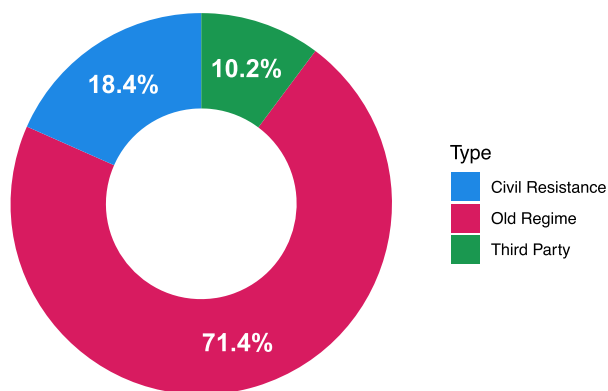


Figure 2 Relation to old regime in overturning attempts.

overturning attempts in civil resistance transitions, disaggregated by the type of organization leading the attempt. The stacked bars show both full success (pink) and partial success (blue) rates for each organizational category. Notably, civil society organizations (Other CSO) demonstrate the highest combined success rate (at over 50%), achieving at least some of their goals more than half the time.

The effectiveness of different organizations in resisting overturning attempts reveals an intriguing reversal of the patterns seen in overturning (see Figure 4). While military and security forces demonstrated relatively low success rates when attempting to overturn transitions, they were remarkably effective in resisting overturning. Interestingly, traditional civil society actors like trade unions and other civil society organizations, while prominent in initiating transitions, have lower overturning prevention rates.

How do these organizations seek to prevent overturning? Public statements are the most frequent tactic, occurring in 78 out of the 86 overturning attempts (see Figure 5). However, surprisingly, the tactic with the highest success rate in preventing overturning attempts is armed violence, successfully preventing overturning attempts from overturning the transition nearly 90% of the time.⁷

Discussion: research applications and future directions

What analyses can scholars conduct with this data? Since the data includes both failed and successful overturning attempts, scholars can use it to distinguish how transitions become at risk of overturning from the process of overturning itself. Our data's temporal structure allows for duration modeling to examine which factors predict the timing of overturning attempts. Cox regression models could test whether, for instance, military defections during the pre-transition civil resistance campaign accelerate or delay subsequent overturning attempts. The attempt-level granularity also enables within-case analysis, looking at why one early overturning attempts in some transitions failed while subsequent ones succeeded.

Scholars can easily link our dataset to existing datasets on mobilization, conflict, and democratization to examine overturning attempts' occurrence, timing, success or failure, and organizational participation as either independent or dependent variables.

The easiest and most direct link is to the various versions of the NAVCO data project, particularly NAVCO 2.1 (Chenoweth & Shay, 2022) whose civil resistance campaigns informed much of our population of civil resistance transitions. Through simple matching on country and campaign end-year, scholars can pair our data with the variables included in NAVCO 2.1 to see how civil resistance campaign characteristics impact transitional politics.

We also provide organization IDs, wherever possible, to link the organizations who overturn and resist overturning to the Anatomy of Resistance Campaigns and V-Party datasets. Connecting our data with these datasets could facilitate any number of analyses on the lifecycles of organizations who participate in maximalist resistance (the ARC population) or on actions of political parties during civil resistance transitions.

The granular start and end dates and detailed actor lists in our data would also make it straightforward to match our dataset with existing conflict datasets such as SCAD, ACLED, or the UCDP GED (Raleigh et al., 2010; Salehyan et al., 2012; Sundberg & Melander, 2013). This would allow for analyses both of the precipitants and consequences of overturning, for instance examining what patterns of lower-level contention (protests, riots, armed clashes, etc...) during transitions tend to escalate into overturning attempts and which do not. Linking the dataset with country-level repression datasets (Cordell et al., 2022) could allow researchers to test whether states with higher baseline repression face more frequent overturning attempts.

Our data comes with many limitations. We do not have access to the "ground truth" underlying our phenomena and instead aggregate and interpret scholarly and media sources, raising concerns of observation bias. We have attempted to minimize this bias through (1) triangulating multiple types of sources with primary reliance on comprehensive historical scholarly accounts; (2) focusing on prominent, national-level phenomenon less likely to be unobserved; and (3) a high degree of coding transparency. On this last point, we document every coding decision for every datapoint in the dataset, including the coder's original sources and their inferential logic, in HTML codesheets released with the data. While this does not eliminate the problem of observation bias, it does provide transparency to identify problems with the data and enable future users to recode specific datapoints if necessary.

The small number of successful overturning cases also limits the kinds of analysis possible with this data. Statistical analysis even of the full dataset is subject to small-*n* issues, and analysis of subsets of the data may simply not be possible. However, even for these kinds of questions the data may still be a useful starting point for analysis due to the rich qualitative information included in the attempt summaries and its detailed set of sources for future research.

What does the data tell us? While we do not engage in inferential statistical analysis in this paper, descriptive examination reveals several intriguing patterns. First, overturning attempts are common but successful overturning is rare. Civil resistance transitions, on average, democratize not because they are unchallenged but because they are resilient to challenges. Old regime elites attempt overturning most frequently, though former civil

⁷ A Wilcoxon rank sum test shows overturning attempts resisted with armed violence are significantly less likely to succeed at $p < 0.01$.

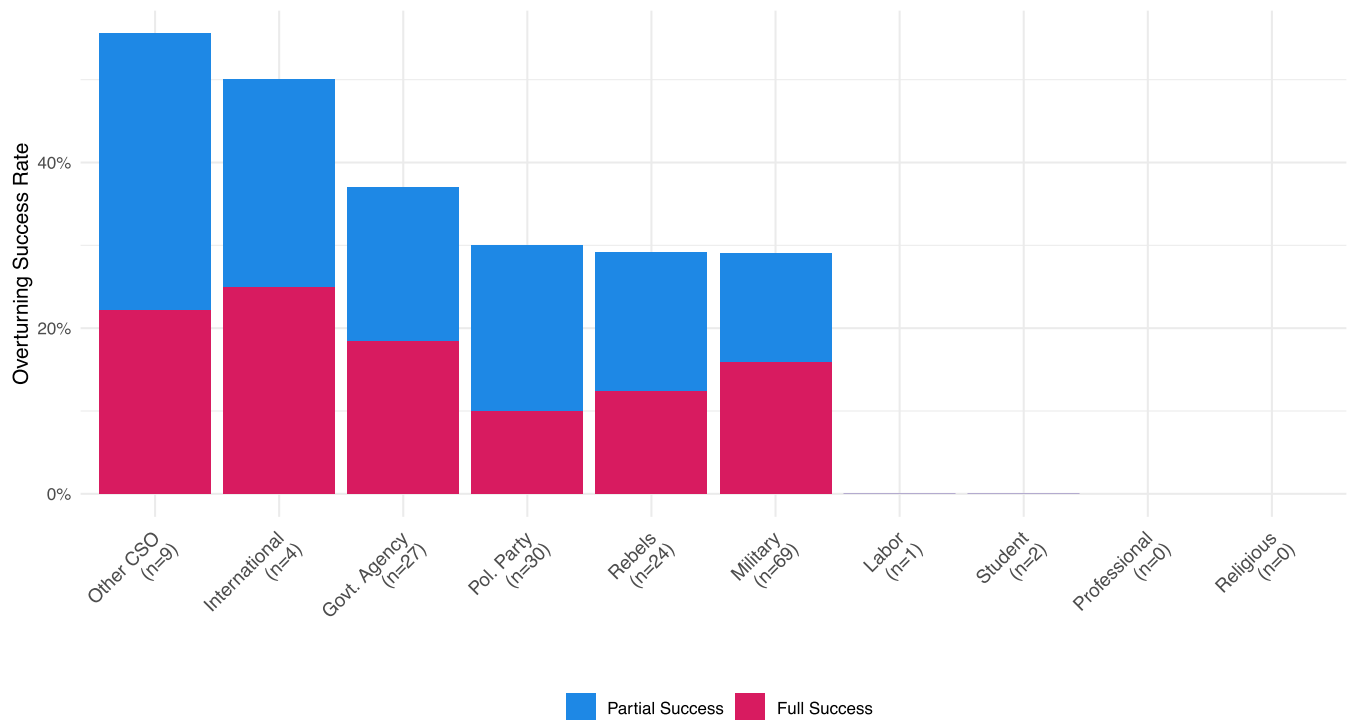


Figure 3 Overturning rates by participating organization. Note: Civil society organizations demonstrate higher overturning success rates than military forces, despite the latter's greater frequency of attempts. Patterns should be interpreted cautiously given varying sample sizes.

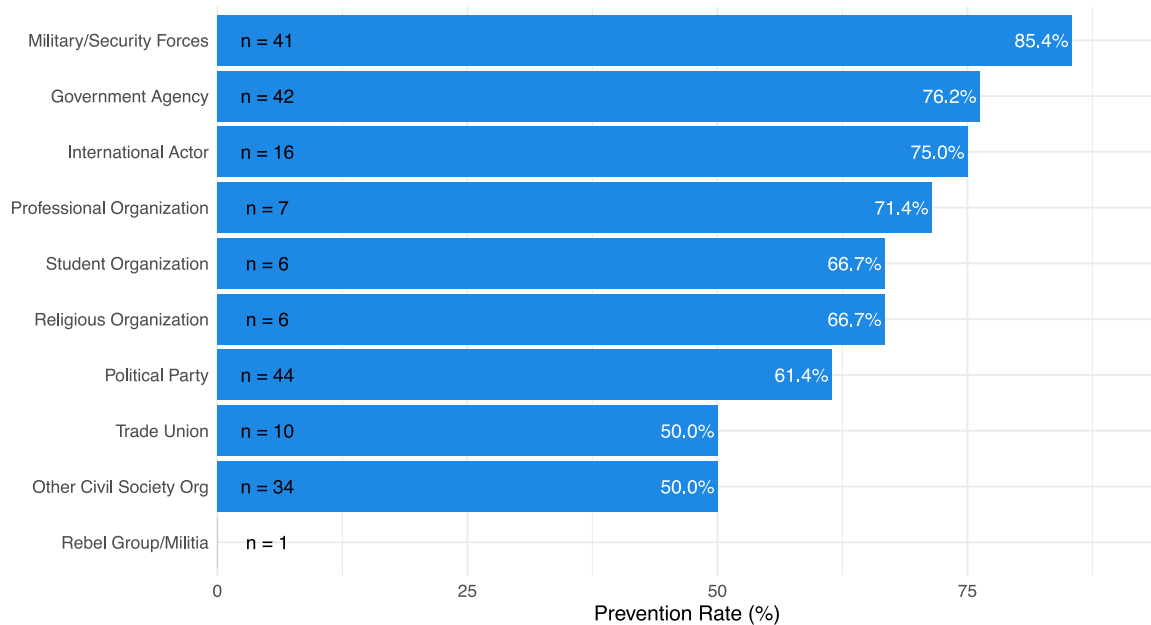


Figure 4 Success rate of resisting overturning by category. Note: Stacked bars show the percentage of overturning attempts in which the organization category named on the x-axis participated and either partially or fully succeeded in overturning democracy.

resistance campaign organizations still participate in many overturning attempts. The military and other security forces are the most common actors seeking to overturn the transition. Yet while the military frequently attempts to overturn transitions, they also frequently fail in these attempts.

Examining the organizations and tactics used to resist overturning attempts helps explain this trend. Just as military actors are the most frequent overturning organization, so are they the most successful resisting organization, and armed violence, most

frequently carried out by military or other security forces, has the highest success rate in resisting overturning. The prominence of armed violence as a tactic for protecting the gains of civil resistance is striking. While unarmed people power may be a potent force for initiating political transitions, setting them on a democratic trajectory, state violence may be a key part of keeping them on that trajectory.

The analysis we have provided here is a descriptive first cut at addressing the path from civil resistance to democracy. Yet it

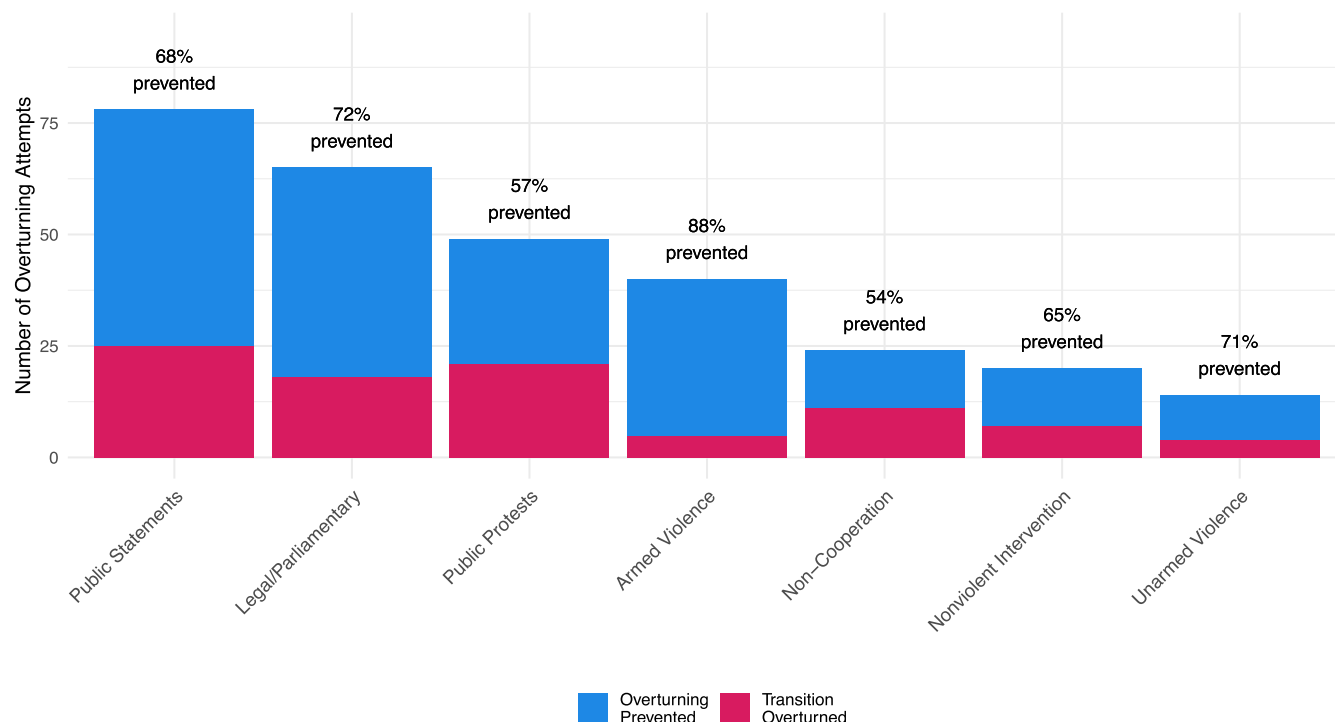


Figure 5 Overturning resistance frequency and success. Note: Stacked bars show the number of overturning attempts where the tactic named on the x-axis was employed to protect democracy. The fill color indicates the outcome of the overturning attempt.

illustrates the richness of the ROAD project to reveal the complex dynamics of this path. With this data scholars and activists can further unpack these dynamics and better understand the critical question of how to get from the nonviolent overthrow of an authoritarian regime to the establishment of a new democracy.

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Author contributions

The authors are ordering their names alphabetically. All authors contributed to investigation, visualization, writing the original draft, and review and editing. In addition, J.P. conceptualized the project, acquired funding, and supervised the project. G.P. also supervised some aspects of the data collection process.

Conflicts of interest

The authors declare that there are no conflicts of interest with respect to the research, authorship, and/or publication of this article.

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Data availability

Data and code to replicate all results from this article are available at <https://www.prio.org/journals/jpr/replicationdata>. In addition, the full dataset, detailed codesheets describing coding decision for each observation in the dataset, and the codebook, are available at <https://github.com/JCPinckney/road-project/>.

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